business model and about any political connections they might have. If the algorithm systematically disappears videos that aren't aligned with the company's political agenda, users should know this.

These are just a few of numerous suggestions made in recent years for how democracies could regulate the entry of bots and algorithms into the public conversation. Naturally, each has its advantages and drawbacks, and none would be easy to implement. Also, since the technology is developing so rapidly, regulations are likely to become outdated quickly. What I would like to point out here is only that democracies *can* regulate the information market and that their very survival depends on these regulations. The naive view of information opposes regulation and believes that a completely free information market will spontaneously generate truth and order. This is completely divorced from the actual history of democracy. Preserving the democratic conversation has never been easy, and all venues where this conversation has previously taken place – from parliaments and town halls to newspapers and radio stations – have required regulation. This is doubly true in an era when an alien form of intelligence threatens to dominate the conversation.

THE FUTURE OF DEMOCRACY

For most of history large-scale democracy was impossible because information technology wasn't sophisticated enough to hold a large-scale political conversation. Millions of people spread over tens of thousands of square kilometres didn't have the tools to conduct a real-time discussion of public affairs. Now, ironically, democracy may prove impossible because information technology is becoming too sophisticated. If unfathomable algorithms take over the conversation, and particularly if they quash reasoned arguments and stoke hate and confusion, public discussion cannot be maintained. Yet if democracies do collapse, it will likely result not from some kind of technological inevitability but from a human failure to regulate the new technology wisely.

We cannot foretell how things will play out. At present, however, it is clear that the information network of many democracies is breaking down. Democrats and Republicans in the United States can no longer agree on even basic facts – such as who won the 2020 presidential elections – and